

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Returning to a damaged home

RECOVERY / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Do not enter a building with gas smell, floodwater, unstable walls, damaged wiring or other serious hazards. A quiet street or an opened road is not proof that a home is safe. Inspect only from a safe outside position and arrange qualified assessment for structural and utility damage. Keep children and pets away.

Do now.

- ☐ **Check the approach**
01 Avoid debris, unstable trees, wires, floodwater and suspicious remnants after conflict. Do not cross a hazard to inspect a property.
- ☐ **Look from outside**
02 Check for leaning walls, sagging roof, fire, gas smell and water around electrical equipment. Do not enter to locate the source of a hazard.
- ☐ **Keep utilities untouched if unsafe**
03 Do not turn on damaged power, gas or flooded equipment. Qualified personnel must assess these systems; do not test them yourself.
- ☐ **Document only when safe**
04 Photograph visible damage from a safe position and retain receipts. Property records are less urgent than staying out of danger.
- ☐ **Use a temporary safe base**
05 Keep sleeping, food and water in safe accommodation while assessment and cleanup are arranged. Separate clean belongings from contaminated items.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Remain in the safest available temporary shelter if inspection services are not operating. Delayed assessment is not permission to occupy a visibly unsafe home.

Watch for.

Do not remove load-bearing debris, enter a confined space or approach explosive debris. Personal inspection cannot certify structural safety.

People & practical needs.

Keep children, pets and people vulnerable to dust or mold outside the work area. Agree who assesses access, who manages dependents and where the clean sleeping and drinking-water space will be. Returning together does not mean every person should enter at once.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

After qualified clearance, plan protective equipment and safe cleanup for the specific hazard. Flood, fire and conflict damage require different precautions. Verify contractors before paying.

Check the next usable option

After qualified clearance, plan protective equipment and safe cleanup for the specific hazard. Flood, fire and conflict damage require different precautions. Verify contractors before paying.

When the first option is unavailable

Remain in the safest available temporary shelter if inspection services are not operating. Delayed assessment is not permission to occupy a visibly unsafe home.

Questions in the field.

Does an open road mean the building is safe?

No. Access and building safety are separate. Check structural damage, water, gas and electrical hazards from a safe position before entering. Where assessment is needed, waiting outside is safer than treating an official access reopening as a building inspection.

What should be documented first?

When safe, record damage and needed repairs before disturbing materials. Keep financial and identity records private and verify anyone offering inspection or cleanup services. Documentation must not delay escape from an immediate hazard.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

[Ready.gov · Recovering from disaster](https://www.ready.gov/recovering-disaster)

<https://www.ready.gov/recovering-disaster>

[CDC · Flood safety](https://www.cdc.gov/floods/about/index.html)

<https://www.cdc.gov/floods/about/index.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/returning-home/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.